

NEVER AN ADEYEMI

EPISODE 1: THE CODICIL

PALMFIRE SEASON 1

Screenplay draft

Based on Mario's final story brief and story bible

Contemporary Lagos romance with stakes

FADE IN:

EXT. IKOYI CEMETERY - DAY

A Lagos sun presses down on black umbrellas. The ADEYEMI family stands beneath a white tent while staff and drivers wait beyond the chairs.

IFEOMA "IFY" OBI, 24, stands beside her father, MR. OBINNA OBI, late fifties, still wearing his driver's jacket.

IFY

You can stand with them.

MR. OBI

I am standing where I am needed.

IFY

That is what you say when you mean you are hiding.

Across the tent, TOBI ADEYEMI, 28, sees Ify. Their recognition is immediate and uncomfortable.

PASTOR

A life is measured by what remains in the people who knew us.

Mr. Obi lowers his eyes. Tobi watches him, not the coffin.

CUT TO:

EXT. ADEYEMI CEMETERY TENT - LATER

Guests move toward the family. Mr. Obi is called away to move a vehicle. Tobi approaches Ify without pretending it is accidental.

TOBI

Ify.

IFY

Tobi Adeyemi.

TOBI

You still use my full name when you are annoyed.

IFY

I have not had enough practice to improve.

A small smile almost survives between them.

TOBI

I did not know you would come.

IFY

My father is working.

TOBI

That is not what I meant.

IFY

It is usually the safest answer.

TOBI

I am sorry.

IFY

For today or for disappearing?

TOBI

I do not know which one you need.

Mr. Obi appears at the edge of the tent. Ify steps away. The old distance returns before either of them can name it.

CUT TO:

EXT. ADEYEMI FAMILY HOME - SIDE GATE - DAY

A black convoy enters through the large front gate. Staff use the smaller side gate. Ify notices the difference.

IFY

They still use this one for us.

MR. OBI

It is a gate.

IFY

It knows what it is.

Tobi comes through the side gate looking for them. YEWANDE ADEYEMI intercepts him.

YEWANDE

Your mother is waiting inside.

TOBI

Ify is a guest.

YEWANDE

That is for your mother to decide.

IFY

Good afternoon.

YEWANDE

Your father has been very helpful today.

IFY

He is always helpful.

Yewande smiles without warmth. From inside, MRS. ADEYEMI calls Tobi's name.

TOBI

I will see you inside.

IFY

I am already inside.

CUT TO:

INT. ADEYEMI FAMILY HOME - STUDY - LATE AFTERNOON

A solicitor, MR. BALOGUN, sits with a sealed will. Kunle stands behind him. Mrs. Adeyemi and Yewande sit together. Mr. Obi and Ify remain near the door.

MR. BALOGUN

I will read the document as written.
Questions may be raised afterward.

MR. BALOGUN

To my wife, the house at Ikoyi. To my sons,
the shares and holdings described in
Schedule A, subject to the conditions
contained in this will and its codicil.

KUNLE

There is a codicil?

MR. BALOGUN

Yes.

KUNLE

You did not tell us.

MRS. ADEYEMI

Your father made decisions without
explaining them.

Balogun opens a second envelope.

CUT TO:

INT. ADEYEMI FAMILY HOME - STUDY - CONTINUOUS

MR. BALOGUN

The executor shall formally offer Mr. Obinna
Obi a forty percent interest in the Adeyemi
operating business.

KUNLE

That is impossible.

MR. BALOGUN

It is written.

KUNLE

My father would not give forty percent of the company to a driver.

IFY

He did not say driver.

TOBI

Kunle.

KUNLE

We are all thinking it.

TOBI

You are the only one saying it.

MR. BALOGUN

The estate remains frozen until Mr. Obi signs acceptance or rejection. The offer must be made without pressure, inducement or condition.

MRS. ADEYEMI

He will reject it.

MR. OBI

I have not said that.

IFY

Why my father?

MR. BALOGUN

Chief reserved that explanation for the formal offer meeting.

Kunle looks at Mr. Obi as if the answer has already been decided. Ify steps between them.

IFY

Do not look at him like he has done something wrong by being named.

CUT TO:

INT. ADEYEMI FAMILY HOME - STUDY CORRIDOR - MOMENTS LATER

KUNLE

You embarrassed me.

TOBI

You called him a driver in front of his daughter.

KUNLE

He is the driver.

TOBI

He is the man Father named.

YEWANDE

A forty-percent interest can destroy a company.

TOBI

Only if the company cannot survive being examined.

KUNLE

When Mr. Obi signs, this is over.

TOBI

You are already planning how to make him sign.

YEWANDE

We are planning how to keep the family standing.

Tobi looks back toward the study, where Mr. Obi and Ify are still waiting.

TOBI

Then stop treating him like the thing that knocked it down.

CUT TO:

EXT. ADEYEMI FAMILY HOME - SIDE GATE - EVENING

IFY

You knew Chief before you worked for him.

MR. OBI

I knew him before this house.

IFY

That is not an answer.

MR. OBI

It is the one I can give here.

IFY

You have been giving me the safe version of your life for twenty-four years.

MR. OBI

I was trying to keep you safe.

IFY

From what?

He cannot answer. The side gate closes behind them.

CUT TO:

INT. ADEYEMI FAMILY HOME - STUDY - NIGHT

The room is empty. Chief's codicil lies open on the desk. An old memorial recording plays faintly from a television in the next room.

CHIEF ADEYEMI (V.O.)

If I cannot repair what my father broke,
then at least I can stop pretending it was
never broken.

The recording cuts off. The line in the codicil remains: MR. OBI
OBI MUST SIGN ACCEPTANCE OR REJECTION.

FADE OUT.